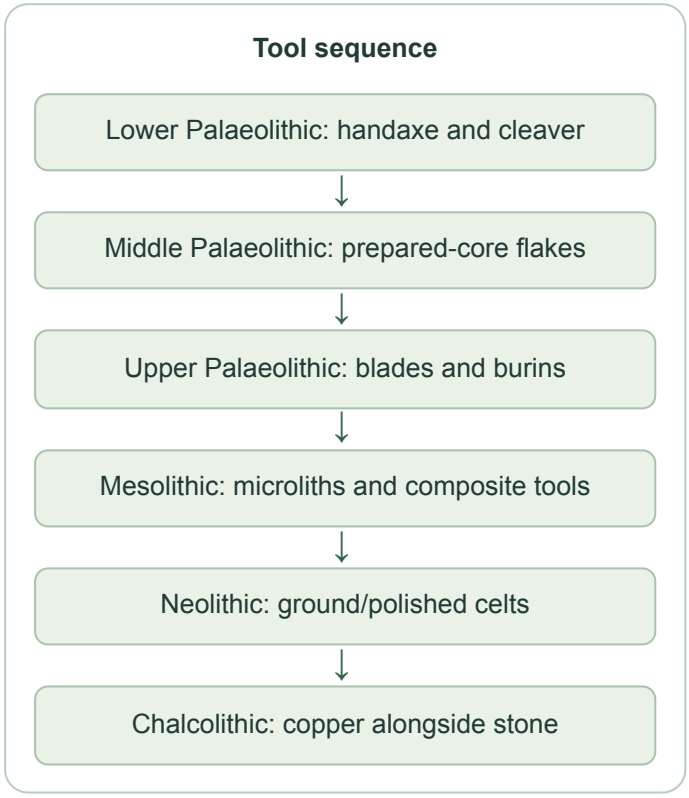
Prehistoric Cultures in India

1. The sequence at a glance

Tool technology + subsistence + archaeological context identify a culture. Regional phases overlap; they are not a single nationwide timetable.



Phase	Conventional chapter range	Main recall
Palaeolithic / Old Stone Age	Globally, roughly 2.5 million years ago to 10,000 BCE in the chapter scheme	Hunter-gatherers; chipped stone tools. This is not a securely dated Indian starting point.
Lower Palaeolithic	Ends around 100,000 BCE in the simplified scheme	Handaxes, cleavers, choppers; Acheulian industry.
Middle Palaeolithic	c.100,000–40,000 BCE in the simplified scheme	Flakes, points, scrapers; prepared cores/Levallois.
Upper Palaeolithic	c.40,000–10,000 BCE	Blades, burins, bone tools; ornaments and symbolic expression.
Mesolithic / Middle Stone Age	c.10,000–7000 BCE in the chapter scheme	Microliths; hunting, fishing, gathering; some animal keeping. Continued much later in several regions.
Neolithic / New Stone Age	c.7000–2000 BCE, with regional variation	Food production, animal keeping, village life, polished tools.

Phase	Conventional chapter range	Main recall
Chalcolithic / Copper-Stone Age	Broadly c.3000–700 BCE	Copper + stone; regional farming villages.
Iron Age	Broadly c.1500–200 BCE in the chapter scheme	Regional iron use; overlaps later Chalcolithic cultures.

- **Pleistocene** broadly frames Palaeolithic developments; **Holocene** frames much Mesolithic/Neolithic activity. Tool phases do not map exactly onto geological subdivisions.
- **Do not memorise 100,000 BCE as the first Indian Middle Palaeolithic everywhere:** Attirampakkam research dates the transition to about **385 ±64 thousand years ago**, with that sequence continuing to about 172 thousand years ago. Original study.
- Chalcolithic villages and the Bronze Age Harappan civilisation **overlapped**. The Iron Age followed the Mature Harappan phase; it did not precede the rise of the Indus civilisation.

2. Evidence and the pioneers

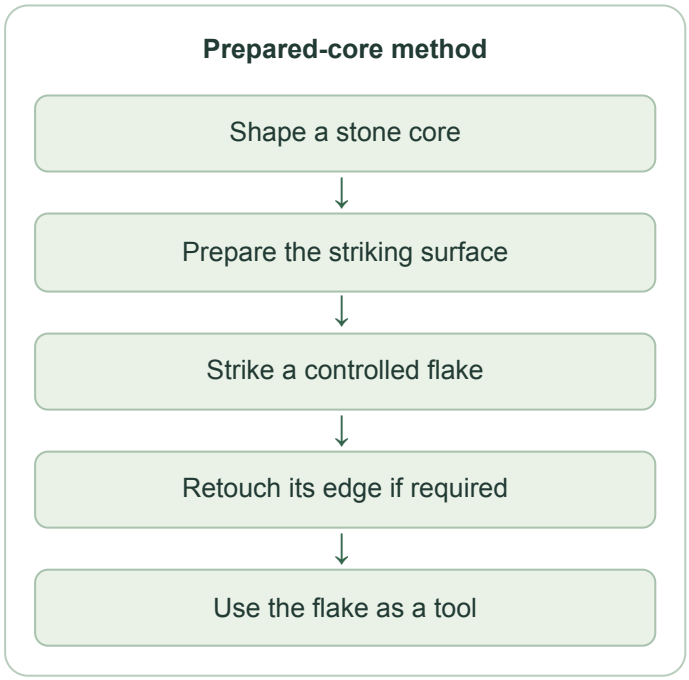
- **Prehistory:** past before usable written records; reconstructed through tools, layers, bones, seeds, houses, burials and art. **Harappan writing remains undeciphered → protohistory**, rather than the beginning of fully readable Indian written history at 2500 BCE.
- **John Lubbock, Pre-historic Times (1865):** introduced the Palaeolithic/Neolithic terminology. “Old/new” refers to archaeological divisions, not human worth.
- **Robert Bruce Foote:** found a Palaeolithic handaxe at **Pallavaram near Chennai, 30 May 1863**; known as the **Father of Indian Prehistory**. First recognised discovery does not mean the oldest tool by archaeological age. Government Museum, Chennai.
- **H. D. Sankalia:** identified Middle Palaeolithic flake industries at **Nevasa on the Pravara, Maharashtra**, in 1956; associated with the term **Nevasian**.
- **A. C. L. Carlyle**, Cunningham's assistant: early recognition of microliths and rock paintings in the **Vindhyan/Mirzapur** shelters; pigment-grinding traces, human/animal remains, ash and charcoal supplied context.

3. Palaeolithic life and tools

- **Economy:** mobile hunting and gathering of wild foods; open-air camps, river valleys, caves and shelters. Regular farming and pottery are not characteristic of the Indian Palaeolithic.
- Quartzite was widely used, hence the older label **“quartzite men”**; limestone, chert and other available rocks were also used. This is a material label, not an ethnic group.
- Do not assign all early Indians to a single “Negrito race”. That typology is outdated; tools alone cannot establish biological ancestry.
- **Homo sapiens evolved in Africa around 300,000 years ago**—not first during the Upper Palaeolithic at 40,000 BCE. Tool industries and biological species are different classifications. Smithsonian.

Tool vocabulary

Tool / technique	Identification and use
Core and flake	Core = stone from which pieces are struck; flake = detached piece, often retouched for use.
Handaxe / cleaver	Bifacially worked handaxe; cleaver has a broad transverse cutting edge. Typical Acheulian forms.
Chopper / scraper	Chopper: worked cutting edge on a cobble; scraper: retouched edge for tasks such as working hides/wood.
Levallois	Prepare the core's shape/surface before striking a flake of intended form; **not perforated Harappan pottery**.
Blade	Elongated flake, conventionally at least about twice as long as wide; many have roughly parallel sides.
Burin	Chisel-like stone edge used for engraving/working hard material such as bone. **A burin is not itself necessarily a bone tool.**
Point / borer	Pointed working end for piercing or other tasks; use depends on wear/context.
Microlith	Small stone implement, often around 1 cm, frequently hafted into a composite tool; sizes vary.
Celt	Ground/polished axe or adze form, strongly associated with Neolithic toolkits.



Lower Palaeolithic: heavy cutting tools

Handaxes, cleavers, choppers and scrapers; much of the phase lies in the Pleistocene. **Acheulian** is characterised especially by bifacial handaxes/cleavers; not every Lower Palaeolithic assemblage is identical.

Site / region	State	Recall
Isampur, Hunsgi valley	Karnataka	Limestone quarry/workshop; handaxes, cleavers, flakes and production waste; near seasonal **Kamta Halla**. Direct evidence of tool manufacture.
Attirampakkam	Tamil Nadu, near Chennai	Stratified Acheulian tools and later prepared-core technologies; key long sequence.
Belan valley	Uttar Pradesh	River-terrace tools; succession across later stone-tool phases.
Adamgarh hills	Madhya Pradesh	Handaxes, cleavers and flakes; later Mesolithic occupation/art.

Middle Palaeolithic: flakes and prepared cores

Flake-based points, scrapers and borers; generally smaller/lighter tools. Prepared, discoidal and Levallois cores; some Late Acheulian forms continued, so replacement was not instant.

Site / region	State	Recall
Nevasa; Chirki–Nevasa basin	Maharashtra	Pravara valley; chalcedony/jasper flakes and scrapers; **Nevasian industry**.
Belan valley	Uttar Pradesh	Quartzite/chert flakes, scrapers and borers; stratified continuity.
Narmada valley	Madhya Pradesh	Flake tools; **Narmada hominin fossil** is important Middle Pleistocene evidence. Its precise species attribution remains debated.
Didwana; Luni basin	Rajasthan	Flakes, points and cores; adaptation to desert-edge/semi-arid settings.
Son valley	Madhya Pradesh–Uttar Pradesh region	Gravel-deposit flakes/blades; technological sequences.
Tirunelveli basin	Tamil Nadu	Flake/prepared-core technologies; southern distribution.
Attirampakkam	Tamil Nadu	Dated early Middle Palaeolithic transition; do not restrict it to the chapter's simplified 100,000–40,000 BCE range.

Upper Palaeolithic: blades, bone working and symbolism

Blade–burin industries, finer implements, ornaments and symbolic activity. Bone points, needles and fishing implements occur in broader Upper Palaeolithic toolkits; their presence must be established site by site.

Site / region	State	Recall
Bhimbetka, Raisen	Madhya Pradesh	Long occupation sequence, blades/burins and rock art; surviving paintings span several periods.
Belan valley	Uttar Pradesh	Blades, scrapers and points; continuity into later phases.

Site / region	State	Recall
Patne, Jalgaon	Maharashtra	Blade industry, beads and **engraved ostrich eggshell**—important early symbolic expression.
Baghor I, Son valley	Madhya Pradesh	Stone tools and a stone arrangement interpreted as a **possible shrine**; an interpretation, not proven ritual meaning.
Kurnool caves	Andhra Pradesh	Bone tools, blades and animal remains; cave-based hunting economy.
Mahadeo hills / Adamgarh	Madhya Pradesh	Blade–burin tools and habitation evidence; regional sequences.
Godavari valley	Telangana / Andhra Pradesh	Blade–flake industries using quartz/chert; smaller tools in later assemblages.
Chitrakoot region	Uttar Pradesh–Madhya Pradesh	Blades, scrapers, burins; open-air/workshop evidence.
Didwana / Luni basin	Rajasthan	Blades, burins and later small-tool traditions in dry environments.
Tirunelveli basin	Tamil Nadu	Blade/small-tool traditions; southern spread.

4. Mesolithic: small tools, diverse livelihoods

- Post-glacial warming changed vegetation, fauna and water availability. Communities hunted, fished and gathered; some adopted animal keeping and increasingly persistent settlements.
- **Microliths** of chert/flint and other rocks could be hafted in wood/bone as arrowheads, spear points or cutting edges. Bone/antler tools supplemented stone.
- Burials, hut floors and food remains reveal community life and diet. Major Ganga-plain settlements belong to this period; this is not proof that no earlier humans ever entered the entire plain.
- Pottery is absent from many early assemblages; it occurs in some later contexts, including **Langhnaj**. Pottery alone does not establish farming.
- Animal skins could be used as clothing; no secure basis for claiming clothing began only in this phase.

Site	State	Recall
Bagor	Rajasthan	Large Mesolithic settlement: microliths, huts, burials, animal bones; evidence of animal keeping in its sequence.
Langhnaj	Gujarat	Microliths, human burials, wild fauna; pottery in the site's sequence.
Adamgarh	Madhya Pradesh	Painted shelters and microliths; long cultural sequence.
Sarai Nahar Rai	Uttar Pradesh	Human burials, animal bones and microliths; community life in the Ganga valley.
Mahadaha	Uttar Pradesh	Burials, habitation floors and microliths; do not infer domestication from settlement alone.
Damdama	Uttar Pradesh	Skeletons, microliths and varied fauna; dietary diversity.

Site	State	Recall
Teri sites	Tamil Nadu	Red sand dunes, microliths and shells; coastal adaptation.
Chopani Mando	Belan valley, Uttar Pradesh	Hut floors, bone tools, microliths and burnt daub with **reed impressions** → wattle-and-daub construction.
Birbhanpur	West Bengal	Microliths and habitation deposits; eastern distribution.
Padri; Loteshwar	Gujarat	Microliths, fauna and pottery in later sequences; contacts with farming communities.

Art: subjects → social evidence

- Rock paintings depict **animals, hunting, dancing, gathering and group activities**. Movement, composition, simplified forms and use of shelter surfaces show aesthetic choices.
- **Bhimbetka:** UNESCO describes paintings from the **Mesolithic through historical periods**; do not date all paintings to one phase. UNESCO.
- Rock art can suggest cooperation, livelihoods and beliefs. It does not by itself prove a fixed gender division of labour or an exact religious doctrine.
- Mesolithic art did **not** mark the global beginning of painting. Natural painted shelters also differ from later deliberately excavated rock-cut caves.

5. Neolithic: food production and villages

Neo = new; lithic = stone. “Neolithic revolution” describes major changes in subsistence and society, occurring unevenly rather than simultaneously.



- **Tools:** ground/polished axes and adzes, sickles, grinding stones; older microliths and bone needles/points/borers continued.

- **Food:** farming and herding supplemented rather than always eliminated hunting/gathering. Surplus storage and processing supported village life.
- **Houses:** circular/rectangular mud, reed and wattle-and-daub structures; pit dwellings in Kashmir. House form depended on region and conditions.
- **Crafts:** pottery for cooking/storage; grey, black-burnished and mat-impressed wares in regional assemblages. Early phases could be **aceramic**; handmade and wheel-made traditions did not begin everywhere together.
- Spinning, weaving, watercraft and wheeled transport developed in different settings; they are **not a compulsory package at every early Neolithic site**.

Site / group	Region	Recall
Mehrgarh	Balochistan, Pakistan, near Bolan Pass	Early farming village, conventionally from **c.7000 BCE**; wheat/barley, sheep/goats/cattle, mud-brick houses, burials and ornaments. Early levels precede pottery.
Burzahom	Kashmir	**Pit dwellings**, bone tools, polished axes; human/animal burials, including dogs.
Mahagara	Uttar Pradesh	Circular huts, polished tools and cattle-related evidence; Ganga-valley farming settlement.
Koldihwa	Belan valley, Uttar Pradesh	Rice-husk impressions in pottery. Early dates/domestication status are debated: avoid an unqualified “oldest cultivated rice” claim.
Belan valley	Uttar Pradesh	Long Mesolithic–Neolithic sequence; animals, pottery, microliths and settlement.
Utnur / Utnoor	Telangana	**Ashmound**, huts, stone axes and cattle remains; southern agro-pastoralism.
Kallur	Karnataka	Southern Neolithic setting; millets/handmade pottery in the chapter account. Iron belongs to later levels, not the defining Neolithic toolkit.
Maski	Karnataka	Stone axes, grains and animal remains; southern Neolithic complex.
Sanganakallu–Kupgal	Karnataka	Extensive settlement/tool-production complex; stone tools, cattle and ashmounds.
Watgal	Karnataka	Microlithic tools, urn/extended burials and grave pots; reported carbonised **betel-nut seeds**.
Budihal	Karnataka	Ashmound, chert working, grinding grooves, bone tools and child burials; evidence interpreted as **community feasting**; wild fruits such as ber and amla.

- **Southern ashmounds:** accumulated burnt cattle dung is central to interpretation; pastoral, seasonal and possible ritual activities matter. Not simply heaps of domestic hearth ash. Southern Neolithic traditions flourished especially during the **third–second millennia BCE**. INFLIBNET, Ravi Korisettar.
- **Rice trap:** cultivation, consumption and full domestication are different claims; secure dating and plant morphology matter. Archaeobotanical research.

6. Chalcolithic: copper did not replace stone

- **Copper + stone** tools; predominantly rural settlements near rivers/hills. Farming, herding, hunting and fishing; pottery, beads and craft exchange.
- Major regional traditions: **Ahar–Banas (Rajasthan), Kayatha/Malwa (central India), Savalda/Jorwe (Maharashtra), Ganeshwar–Jodhpura (Rajasthan)**.
- Broad chapter range **c.3000–700 BCE**; **Ganeshwar–Jodhpura c.2800–2200 BCE** is a conventional regional range, not the starting date of copper use everywhere.
- Chalcolithic is a technological/cultural category: many villages coexisted with Harappan Bronze Age towns. It is not a uniform stepping stone that everywhere ended before bronze began.
- **Copper-hoard anthropomorph:** stylised human-shaped object; **Madarpur, Moradabad, Uttar Pradesh** is an important findspot.

Site / culture	State	Recall
Ahar / Ahar–Banas	Rajasthan	Black-and-red ware, copper, mud houses and stone blades; farming/metallurgy.
Balathal	Rajasthan	Fortification, copper tools, cattle remains and storage structures.
Gilund	Rajasthan	Ahar–Banas: storage complex, terracotta figurines and seal impressions; exchange/craft activity.
Kayatha	Madhya Pradesh	Early central Indian Chalcolithic culture; painted pottery, copper and blades.
Navdatoli	Madhya Pradesh	Malwa culture; circular huts, microliths, painted pottery; wheat/barley/pulses and livestock.
Eran	Madhya Pradesh	Malwa-related painted pottery, copper and beads. The supplied “Ernabad” is treated as a site-name error.
Inamgaon	Maharashtra, Ghod valley	Major excavated Malwa–Jorwe farming settlement; houses, storage, tools and distinctive burials. **Jorwe, not Inamgaon, is the type-site of Jorwe culture.**
Jorwe	Maharashtra	Type-site; painted pottery with geometric designs and copper objects.
Nevasa	Maharashtra	Malwa/Jorwe pottery, microliths and copper; multi-period occupation.
Daimabad	Maharashtra	Large settlement; metal animal figures—**elephant, rhinoceros, buffalo**—and a wheeled vehicle/charioteer; important metalwork.
Savalda	Maharashtra	Earlier regional pottery tradition; red painted/handmade wares; precedes Jorwe in regional sequences.
Ganeshwar–Jodhpura	Rajasthan	Numerous copper arrowheads/fishhooks and other objects, pottery and microliths; links to wider Harappan-period exchange.
Nokoda; Ojiyana	Rajasthan	Ahar–Banas-associated sites named in the chapter.
Prabhas Patan / Somnath	Gujarat	Coastal Chalcolithic tradition; black-and-red ware and copper.
Tekkalkota / Tekkalakota	Karnataka	Southern Neolithic–Chalcolithic sequence; copper, pottery and fauna.

7. Exam practice and answer framework

CSE Mains 2015 · GS I · 12.5 marks · 200 words

“Mesolithic rock cut architecture of India not only reflects the cultural life of the times but also a fine aesthetic sense comparable to modern painting. Critically evaluate this comment.”

- Open with painted **natural rock shelters**, exemplified by Bhimbetka; distinguish them from later excavated rock-cut architecture.
- **Cultural life:** hunting, animals, group dancing and gathering suggest subsistence, cooperation and social occasions.
- **Aesthetics:** expressive outlines, movement, composition and use of rock contours; simple forms can convey complex action.
- **Critique:** scenes are selective; dates/interpretations vary, and “comparable” does not establish the same purpose or historical context as modern painting.
- End: art is valuable evidence of material and imaginative life, read with tools, burials and environmental remains.

Supplied other-exam questions

1. CDS II 2023 — Levallois technique

Consider the following statements regarding the ‘Levallois Technique’:

1. It refers to making perforated Harappa pottery.

2. It refers to making prehistoric flake tools.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only; (b) 2 only; (c) Both 1 and 2; (d) Neither 1 nor 2.

Answer: (b). Prepared-core flake production; not pottery.

2. CDS II 2023 — Palaeolithic tools

1. Isampur was a well-known center of stone tool manufacture located in Gulbarga district of Karnataka and was situated along a small seasonal stream known as Kamta Halla.

2. A Paleolithic blade is a flake tool, the length of which is more than twice its width.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only; (b) 2 only; (c) Both 1 and 2; (d) Neither 1 nor 2.

Answer: (c), as supplied. Isampur = Karnataka quarry/workshop; blade = elongated flake.

3. CAPF 2023 — Neolithic period

Which one among the following statements with reference to the ‘Neolithic Period’ is **not correct**?

(a) The characteristic features of the period included ground and polished stone tools, agriculture, animal domestication and pottery.

(b) This period is also known as the ‘New Stone Age’.

(c) The characteristic features appeared almost at the same time in various parts of the subcontinent.

(d) Earliest evidence of agriculture is found from Mehrgarh around 8000 BCE.

Answer: (c), as supplied. Regional transitions were uneven. Option (d)'s date is reproduced faithfully; for revision use the conventional **c.7000 BCE** beginning of Mehrgarh, with dating discussions kept distinct from an exam's supplied wording.

8. Last-minute recall

- **Handaxe → flake → blade/burin → microlith → polished celt → copper + stone.**
- **Isampur:** quarry; **Nevasa:** Nevasian; **Patne:** ostrich eggshell; **Baghor I:** possible shrine.
- **Bagor:** Rajasthan; **Langhnaj:** Gujarat; **Sarai Nahar Rai–Mahadaha–Damdama:** Uttar Pradesh.
- **Mehrgarh:** wheat/barley; **Burzahom:** pits; **Koldihwa:** rice evidence; **Utnur–Budihal:** ashmounds.
- **Ahar–Gilund–Balathal:** Rajasthan; **Navdatoli–Eran:** Malwa; **Inamgaon–Jorwe–Daimabad:** Maharashtra.
- A tool's shape, a site's age and a hominin's species are separate questions. **Not all microliths are exclusively Mesolithic; not all Neolithic communities had pottery from the outset.**